

Modernity as a Colonial Project?

Structure of Lecture

- 3 parts:
- Defining Modernity (or not) and its relation to Sociology.
- Sociology, Modernity and Colonialism
- Reading this week's reading – Dussel

Part 1 – Defining Modernity and Sociology (or not)

Should we define “modernity”?

Perhaps definitions are part of the problem (we will come back to this in a later lecture when we look at Foucault on Power/Knowledge)

- Most sociologists ignored the role of the “rest of the world” in modernity.
- Sociology has tended to imagine that its ideas come from and apply only to Western Europe (and then the USA)
- But one main point is that definitions of modernity seem to suggest that those societies/countries which are not “modern” are not ordered, progressing or reasonable
- Instead, they are seen as chaotic, traditional, irrational
- This is something we need to think about. Carefully.



Defining Modernity (or not)

- The most I am prepared to say (at this stage) is that: modernity is a way of thinking, acting and living which had and still has enormous and unequal consequences for the world and the peoples of the world.
- Before you class, try and think of an example of how those countries which are seen as “less modern” than the West have been thought of as “backward” or “traditional”.



A Colonial “Attitude”

- One way of thinking about this lecture was to see it as tracing the development of “a colonial attitude”
- Of course there is much more to colonialism than just an attitude
- But I think that this attitude toward “the colonies”, towards peoples, lives on even though the most countries have attained independence (independence from...)
- I will come back to this throughout the lecture.



Sociology and Modernity (1)

- Sociology:
- “is a creature of modernity”.
- It was created in the modern era.
- It tries to explain what it means/what it is like to be “modern”.
- In one sense it helped create the modern era.
- And I think it also helped create this “colonial attitude”....



To put it another way:

Sociology and Modernity (2)

- Sociology, as an academic discipline, arose within and is an attempt to account for modernity. It is a thoroughly modern subject.
 - Marx, Durkheim and Weber were all trying to explain new (“modern”) societies which were based on:
 - Industrialization (factories)
 - Urbanization - Move of populations to cities from agricultural land
 - Individualization - Many of the classical theorists describe modernity in terms of a (paradoxical) tension between the individualizing character of modernity and the rise of wider anonymous social collectivities.
 - [Marx – commodification and alienation
 - Weber – rationalization and disenchantment
 - Durkheim – complex division of labour as the basis of society and anomie]
- Fair enough, you may say. But how did they do this?....

A Summary/Re-cap

Sociology's (colonial) attitude toward modernity

- When sociologists try to define modernity (which is hard to do), it is amazing how often they say how it involves a break with the past, with tradition, religion, customs, etc.
- In doing so, they seem to suggest that anyone or any country which has not been part of this route, is not just “pre-modern” but is, in some way, “back in time” or “backward”.
- For example, - think about Durkheim.
- He sees the shift to modernity as going from Mechanical to Organic Societies
- This suggests that other societies around the world are still “pre-modern”/behind/backward...

Part 2 – Sociology, Modernity and Colonialism.

Sociology sees Modernity as unsettling, dynamic, on-going (and “Western”)...

- Everything can and must be constantly re-evaluated

Traditions

History

Fashion

Culture

Life

(This does not apply to those countries which were “colonized”).



For example – the question of time and history

One key feature of modernity is its view of time:

- Time moves forward
- The economy is always growing.
- Communication is getting faster
- Fashion changes every year (or every few months, or weeks...)
- The experience of modernity is one of speed
- History means change.
- Europe and the “West” have history.
- Does the rest of the world?
- (This is taken up in the Dussel reading)



Modernity and Time and “Colonialism”

- Those countries/societies which are not thought to be modern are seen as having different approaches to time.
- The cycles of harvests
- Tradition
- Things always stay the same (this is one reason we go to visit on holiday!).



Here is one example of a “colonial attitude”...

- [A legacy of colonialism](#)
- But that is “just Boris being Boris” you might say...
- I think there are other examples around us...

Music.....

For example:

- What about Beethoven and Mozart and Bach?....
 - “Western Classical Music” is seen as “universal” – their music could be enjoyed by anyone in the world
 - And people from around the world study and learn their music (because it is thought of as the “best”).
 - There is a strange linking of rationality and emotion in all this
 - And a strong belief that there is something “great” about Western Classical Music.
- **Villa-Lobos: Bachianas Brasileiras: -**
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wF3OorFR4lg>
 - **João Bosco**
 - <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dR5Up5gnGak>

A Colonial Attitude (2)

- We tend to call things which are not Western “classical” music – World Music (Gamelan, samba, etc)
- This is a privileging of Western music
- And it tends to diminish music and musicians who play other forms of music
- We should think of Beethoven and Bach as local, “ethnic” musicians
- I think the same applies to “pop” music
- And “art”.
- This is a big topic. Perhaps we can talk about it in class.
- I wrote an article on the tuning of musical instruments which relates to this:
- [Equal Temperament](#)



As we saw last week, one possible exception is Marx:

- **“Without slavery you have no cotton; without cotton you have no modern industry. It is slavery that gave the colonies their value; it is the colonies that created world trade and it is world trade that is the pre-condition of large-scale industry.” (Marx, 1977: 203 - *Karl Marx – Selected Writings* (ed. McLellan), Oxford University Press.**

And Du Bois, of course....BUT BE CAREFUL

- ‘the fifteenth century there was no great disparity between the civilization of Negroland* and that of Europe’ Du Bois, 1970: 86
- The consequences of the Haitian revolution (1790-1804) were enormous. Napoleon gave up his ideas of an empire in America and sold Louisiana for nothing and the fear of such revolutions affected the US throughout the 19th century – Du Bois, 1970: 103, 105
- ‘The chief island domain of English slavery was Jamaica. It was Oliver Cromwell who, in his zeal for God and the slave trade, sent an expedition to seize Hayti. His fleet, driven off there, took Jamaica in 1655.’ Du Bois, 1970: 107
- ‘The new colonial theory transferred the reign of commercial privilege and extraordinary profit from the exploitation of backward races under the political domination of Europe. For the purpose of carrying out this idea the European and white American working class was practically invited to share in this new exploitation, and particularly were flattered by popular appeals to their inherent superiority to....
- *this is a term which Du Bois “invented” – and refers to an area within Africa.

Looking at the Reading in the
Module Reader:

Enrique Dussel

- Dussel points out that the ideas of writers such as Durkheim, Giddens and others are not as clear or innocent as they might first appear.
- According to Dussel, most writers:-
- Assume that modernity is an exclusively Western, European phenomenon
- Do not realise that while modernity appears to celebrate rationality and freedom, it also encourages violence towards those who are not so “modern” or “rational”.
- They are part of the development of what I have called a “colonial attitude”.

Dussel's main points (1):

- Modern Europe sees itself as the most developed (superior)
- This superiority “obliges” Europe to uplift/educate other societies (Iraq, Brazil, Saudi Arabia?)
- The path of development should follow that of the growth of the “modern world” out of the middle ages.

Dussel's main points (2):

- Where there is opposition, in the last resort, violence is necessary to impose the “reasonableness” of modernity (Iraq, Falklands?)
- It is the “fault” of those who are not modern that they are not modern.

What is his “evidence”

- Writers such as Hegel and Kant...
- Kant said that humans had a duty to rid themselves of ignorance.
- This is the role of reason. He writes:
- “Laziness and cowardice are the reasons why the greater part of humanity remains in a state of immaturity”.
- But...

- Does this imply that anyone not taking part in modernity is immature?
- Is this how we think of those “others” around the world?
- Probably:
- “The Negroes of Africa have by nature no feeling that rises above the ridiculous”. Kant, I. (1992): Observations on the feeling of the beautiful and sublime. in: Kant, I. (1992): Lectures on Logic, pp. 18-62. Cambridge University Press. Cambridge, p. 59.
- (We will return to the question of “race” next term).

Hegel on “World History” (all quotations in the module reader)

- ‘The world is divided into the Old World and the New World’
- ‘The movement of Universal History goes from the East to the West’
- ‘The Mediterranean sea is ... the center of all Universal History’
- This is still with us in the idea that European culture is “founded” on the Greeks and Roman culture/politics/law/history

(Personally, I don’t think we should take the status of Roman and Greek culture for granted as part of the “West”. These empires were “Mediterranean”, North African, Asian (in the sense of “Asia Minor”). We will look at some of these ideas next term in the work of Edward Said.)

More Hegel quotations from Dussell reading

- 'Africa is in general a closed land'
- 'Among negroes it is the case that consciousness has not attained even the intuition of any sort of objectivity...'
- '[The negro] is the man as beast'
- (Again, we will return to such ideas next term).

But surely “we” don’t think such things now?...

- Well, think back to the clip of Boris Johnson.
- For your classes I would like you to think of other examples of how a “colonial attitude” plays out today.
- Sport?
- Music?
- Fashion?
- Education (which are the best universities in the world, and why?)
- Etc. etc.